

Theseus and the Legends of Attica



Descendants of Erechtheus, fortunate from of old and children of the blessed gods, dwelling in a land that has never been ravaged, feeding on most famous wisdom . . .

—EURIPIDES, *Medea*, 824–829

The Early Kings and Their Legends

Cecrops, Erichthonius, and Erechtheus

The Athenians boasted that they were **autochthonous** (literally, “sprung from the earth”), that is, that they were not descended from any invaders of Attica. They said that Cecrops, their earliest king, had sprung from the earth and was serpent-shaped in the lower half of his body. He has little importance in legend except as the founder of Attica, which he called Cecropia after himself. It was in his time that the contest between Poseidon and Athena for the possession of Attica took place (see pp. 177–178). Poseidon continued to be an important divinity at Athens, and his worship on the Acropolis was closely connected with that of Athena.

Another early figure in Attic mythology is Erichthonius, who was also partly serpent-shaped and (as the element *-chthon-* in his name implies) sprung from the earth. When Hephaestus attempted to violate Athena, his semen fell on the ground, and from it sprang Erichthonius. Athena took him up and put him in a chest, which she gave to the daughters of Cecrops, Pandrosos, Auglauros, and Herse (or only to Pandrosos), forbidding them to look inside. The sisters disobeyed: driven mad by what they saw (either a pair of snakes or Erichthonius



The Discovery of the Infant Erichthonius, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on canvas, ca. 1616, 85 × 125 in. Rubens has painted the moment when Aglauros has opened the basket containing Erichthonius and shows him to her sisters, Pandrosos (on the right) and Herse (on the left) with a brilliant red robe. Cupid gestures toward her as the future bride of Mercury. Behind is a fountain of the many-breasted Artemis, whose fertility is echoed by the herm of the lascivious god Pan, on the left. The identity of the old woman is not known. (Courtesy of the Collections of the Prince of Liechtenstein, Vaduz Castle, Liechtenstein)



Closer Look

with his snakelike body), they hurled themselves off the Acropolis.¹ After this, Athena took Erichthonius back and brought him up herself. As king of Athens, he was credited with instituting the great annual festival of the Panathenaea and setting up the wooden statue of Athena on the Acropolis.

Erichthonius' myth focuses on his birth, the most important feature of which is that he was "sprung from the earth." He is to some extent confused with his grandson and successor as king of Athens, Erechtheus. Both are in fact forms of Poseidon. Athena prophesied that after his death Erechtheus would be worshiped at Athens with his own cult-site, "ringed around with stones," and that under the title of "**Poseidon-Erechtheus** he will be offered sacrifices of bulls."²

Toward the end of the fifth century, the beautiful temple on the Acropolis known as the **Erechtheum** was dedicated jointly to **Athena Polias** (i.e., Athena as Guardian of the City) and Erechtheus.³ In it were sacred objects associated with the earliest stages of Athenian religion, including the wooden statue of Athena, the tomb of Erechtheus, and the salt spring produced by the blow of Poseidon's trident in his contest with Athena, which was known as "the sea of Erechtheus." In this "sea" were the marks of Poseidon's trident where he struck the earth, and linked to the sanctuary was the olive tree produced by Athena. The temple

took the name by which it is generally known, Erechtheum, from Erechtheus-Poseidon; but in antiquity it was known officially as “the temple in which is the ancient statue.”

Thus the Erechtheum and its neighboring shrines were closely bound up with the most ancient myths of Athens. It was built upon the Acropolis, the site of the Mycenaean fortress of Athens, and so it linked Athenians to the earliest stages of their city’s history. Athena, the great Olympian protectress of the city, here was associated with both her rival Poseidon and her predecessor, the chthonic divinity Erechtheus. Her triumph in the struggle for the honor of protecting the city was visible nearby in the sculptures of the west pediment of the Parthenon.

Erechtheus was important in the mythology of Athens. He successfully defended Athens in her earliest war, the attack of the Eleusinians led by the Thracian Eumolpus, who was a son of Poseidon and ancestor of the hereditary priests of Eleusis. With the approval of his wife, Praxithea, Erechtheus sacrificed one (or all three) of his daughters to secure the victory for Athens.⁴ In the battle he killed Eumolpus, and for this deed was himself killed by Poseidon, who thrust him into the earth with his trident. The sacrifice of the daughter was a central theme in Euripides’ tragedy *Erechtheus*, in which Praxithea played a prominent part.⁵

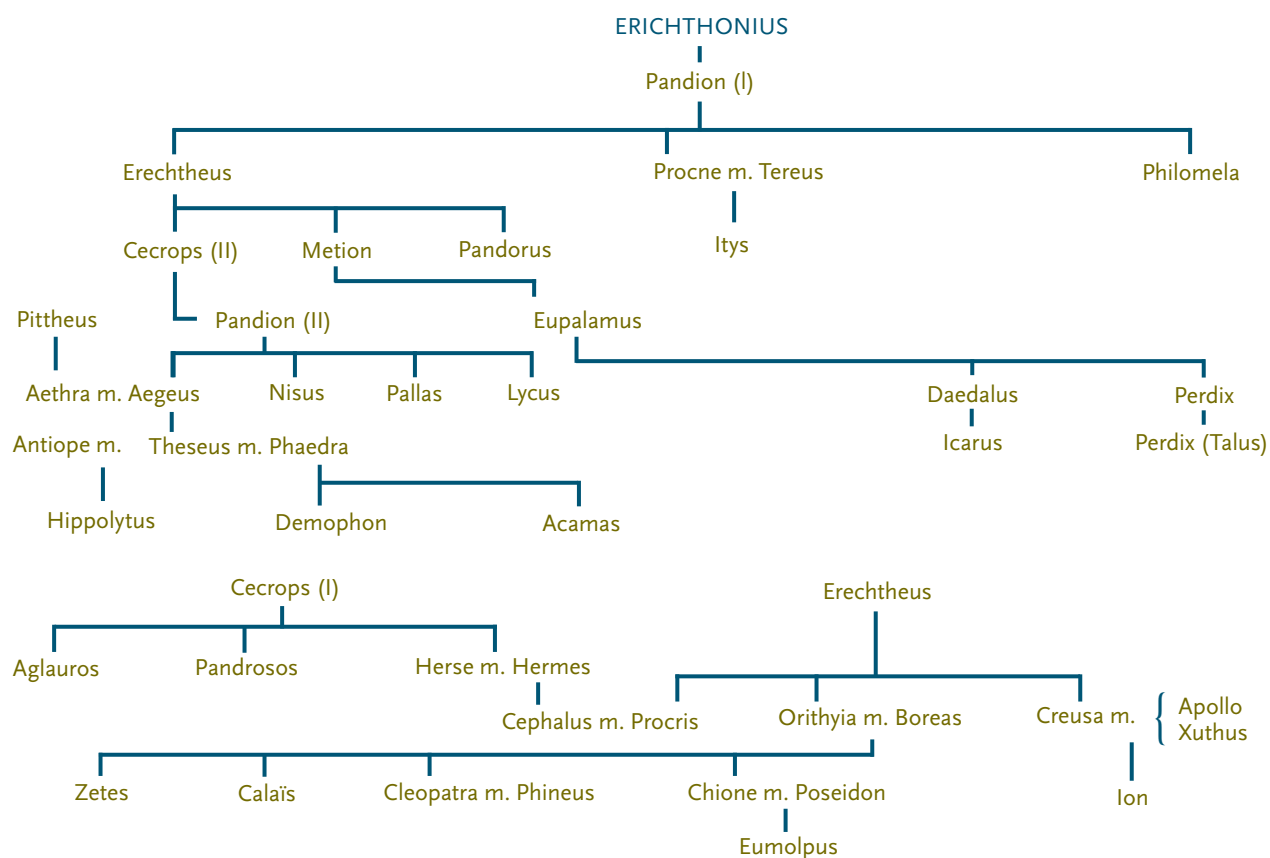


Figure 23.1. The Royal Families of Athens

In Euripides' tragedy *Ion*, Ion's mother, **Creusa**, one of Erechtheus' daughters, gives a different version, in which all the daughters of Erechtheus were sacrificed except for herself (*Ion* 277–282):

ION: Did your father Erechtheus sacrifice your sisters?
 CREUSA: He hardened himself to kill the maidens as a sacrificial offering for the earth.
 ION: How then were you saved alone amongst your sisters?
 CREUSA: I was a newborn baby in my mother's arms.
 ION: And does a chasm in the earth truly hide your father?
 CREUSA: Yes—blows from the ocean-god's trident killed him.

As a final reminder of Erechtheus' importance in Athenian mythology and the pride of the Athenians in being autochthonous, we quote from the opening lines (824–830) of the beautiful chorus in praise of Athens that Euripides composed for his tragedy *Medea*.⁶

The descendants of Erechtheus are fortunate from of old and children of the blessed gods, [dwelling in] a holy land that has never been conquered, feeding on most famous wisdom and walking lightly through the shining air.

We have earlier mentioned the daughters of Cecrops to whom Athena entrusted the infant Erichthonius. They were three in number, Aglauros, Herse, and Pandrosos, whose names, meaning “bright,” “dew,” and “all-dew,” respectively, show that they are truly mythological beings, in origin fertility goddesses.⁷

Ovid tells how Herse was loved by Hermes, who was first noticed by Aglauros as he flew down to the Acropolis. Aglauros asked Hermes for gold as a reward for her help in bringing him to Herse. For this Aglauros further angered Athena, who was already angry because of her disobedience in looking inside Erichthonius' chest. Athena therefore filled Aglauros with such envy that she tried to prevent Hermes from going in to Herse and he turned her into a rock. Hermes then lay with Herse, and their son was Cephalus.

Cephalus and Procris

Cephalus was loved by **Eos (Dawn)** and was an ally of Amphytrion. In later legend, he is the husband of Procris, daughter of Erechtheus. In Ovid's story, Cephalus was tempted by **Aurora** (the Latin form of Eos), who also loved him, to make trial of Procris' faithfulness. In disguise Cephalus attempted to seduce her, and when he was on the point of succeeding, revealed himself. In shame Procris fled and joined Artemis, who gave her a hound, **Laelaps**, that always caught its quarry and a javelin that never missed its mark. Later, she was reconciled to Cephalus and returned home, bringing with her the magic gifts. According to Ovid, the hound was turned into marble, along with its prey, when Cephalus was hunting near Thebes. The javelin had a longer and more tragic history. Here is part of Ovid's story (*Metamorphoses* 7. 804–859; Cephalus is the speaker):

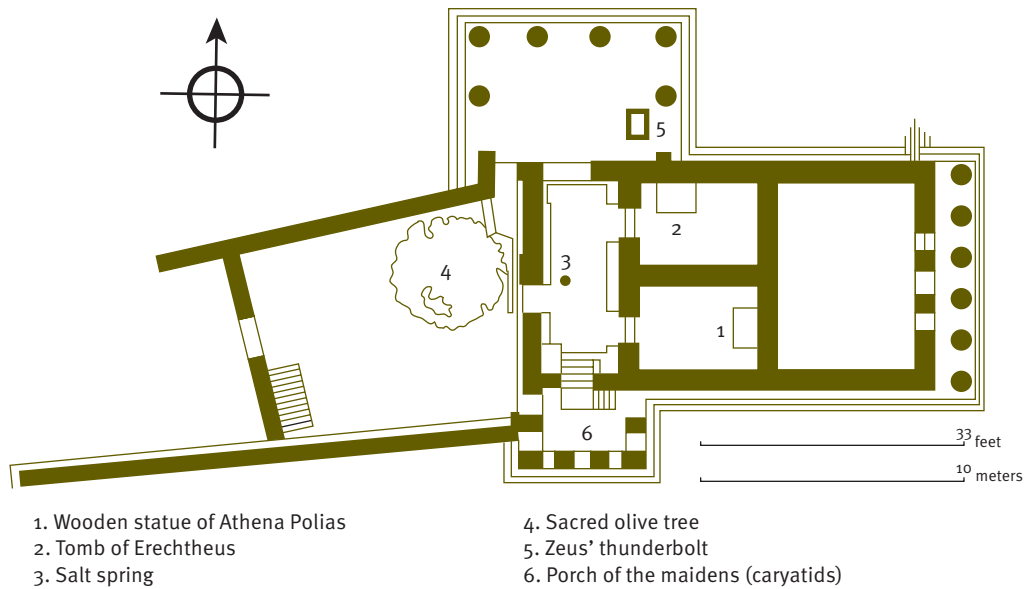


Figure 23.2. Plan of the Erechtheum (after W. B. Dinsmoor)



Audio

When the sun's first rays had just begun to touch the topmost peaks, I used to go, like the young man I was, to the forest to hunt. No servants went with me, nor horses, nor keen-scented dogs trained to follow the knotted hunting nets—all I relied upon was the javelin. When my right hand had had enough of killing wild beasts, I would look for the cool shade and the breeze (*aura*) that came from the cold valleys. The gentle breeze would I call for in the midday heat; the breeze would I wait for, refreshment after my labors. "Come, Aura" (for I remember my words), would I sing, "assist me and most pleasing, enter my bosom; be willing to relieve as you do, the heat with which I burn."⁸ Perhaps I would add (for this way tended my fate) more endearments and would say, "You

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Someone listening to my words with their double meaning was deceived; thinking the name of *aura* that I called upon so often was the name of a nymph, she believed that it was a nymph I loved. Soon a rash informer falsely charged me before Procris and repeated the murmurings she had heard. Love is credulous, yet often Procris hesitated and refused to believe the informer; she would not condemn her husband's crime unless she saw it herself. (821–834)

The next dawn's light had driven the night away: I went to the forest and, successful in the hunt, lay on the grass and said, "Come, Aura, and give relief to my labor." Suddenly I thought I heard a sob as I spoke, yet still as I was saying, "Come, most excellent Aura," a fallen leaf rustled; and, thinking it was a wild animal, I hurled my javelin through the air. It was Procris; and as she held her wounded breast, she groaned "Ah, me." When I recognized the voice of my faithful wife, headlong I ran to her in dismay. I found her half dead, her blood staining her torn clothes, and plucking her own gift, alas, from the wound. Gently I lifted her body, dearer to me than my own . . . and implored her not to leave me, guilty of her death. (835–850)

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Weakened and on the point of death, with an effort she said these few words: “By our marriage vows . . . and by my love that still endures, the cause, even as I am dying, of my death, do not let Aura take my place as your wife.” Those were her words; then finally I realized how she had mistaken the name and told her of the mistake. Yet what use was it to tell her? She fainted away, and her feeble strength failed as her blood flowed out.⁹ (851–859) 30

Philomela, Procne, and Tereus

The successor of Erichthonius was Pandion, who is famous in legend chiefly for his daughters Philomela and Procne. The Thracian king Tereus came to help Pandion in a war against Thebes and was rewarded with the hand of Procne. He took her back to Thrace and by her became the father of **Itys**. Later, Philomela came to visit her sister and was attacked by Tereus, who violated her, cut out her tongue, and shut her up in a remote building deep in the forest. Here is how Ovid continues the story (*Metamorphoses* 6. 572–600):

What could Philomela do? Her prison, with its walls of unyielding stone, kept her from flight. Her mouth, dumb, could not tell of the crime. Yet sorrow is inventive, and cunning is an ally in distress. Skillfully she hung the threads from the barbarian loom and interwove purple scenes with the white threads,



Audio



Cephalus and Aurora, by Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665); oil on canvas, ca. 1630, 38 × 51 ½ in. Cephalus gazes at a portrait of Procris, held up to him by a cupid, as he resists the advances of Aurora. In the background, Pegasus waits to pull the chariot of the Dawn. The sleeping god with the urn is a river-god used by Poussin to signify a mythological landscape. (© National Gallery, London/Art Resource, NY)

telling of the crime. She gave the finished embroidery to a servant and by signs asked her to take it to her mistress. The servant, not knowing what she was bringing, obeyed and took the embroidery to Procne. The cruel tyrant's wife unrolled the tapestry and read the unhappy saga of her own misfortunes. She held her peace (a miracle that she could!); sorrow restrained her words. . . . (572–583)

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Now came the time when the Thracian matrons celebrated Bacchus' triennial feast; Night accompanied their rites. Queen Procne left her palace, garbed in the god's ritual dress and holding the instruments of his ecstasy. . . . In a frenzy, with threatening looks, Procne rushed through the forest with a crowd of followers; driven by the madness of sorrow she pretended, Bacchus, that it was your madness. At length she reached the lonely prison and raised the Bacchic cry, *Εὐοε*; she broke down the doors, seized her sister, and put on her the Bacchic vestments, veiling her face with leaves of ivy. Dragging the stunned Philomela, Procne brought her sister to the palace. (587–600)

Ovid then tells how Procne decides to revenge herself upon Tereus by murdering their son Itys (636–645):

Without delay, Procne seized Itys. . . . In a distant part of the lofty palace, as he stretched out his hands (for he saw his fate before him) and cried, "Mother, mother," trying to embrace her, she struck him with a sword, where the chest meets the body's flank, and she did not look away. One wound was enough to kill him, but Philomela cut his throat with a knife. They tore apart his body, while it still retained vestiges of life.

Ovid describes, in considerable detail, how the sisters cooked Itys and served him up to Tereus, who recognized too late what he had eaten. The tale continues (666–674):

Now Tereus drew his sword and pursued the daughters of Pandion: you would think that their bodies were clothed with feathers, and indeed they were. One flew to the forest; the other to the roof, and still the murder marked her breast and her feathers were stained with blood. Tereus, rushing swiftly in sorrow and in eagerness for revenge, turned into a bird with crested head; a long beak projects in place of his sword; the bird's name is Epops (Hoopoe), and its face seems armed.

In the Greek version of the story, it is the nightingale (Procne) that mourns for her dead son, while the tongueless swallow (Philomela) tries to tell her story by her incoherent chatter. The Latin authors, however, changed the names, making Philomela the nightingale and Procne the swallow.

The *Ion* of Euripides

Pandion was said to have been succeeded as king by Erechtheus, whose myths we discussed earlier. Among his daughters was Creusa, the heroine of Euripides' play *Ion*. Creusa was the only one of the daughters not to have been sacrificed by her father before the battle against Eumolpus. She was loved by Apollo and bore him a son, Ion, whom she exposed out of fear of her father. Ion was



The Banquet of Tereus,
by Peter Paul Rubens
(1577–1640); oil on canvas,
1636–1638, 77 × 105 in.
Procne, wearing a Maenad's
animal skin, shows the head
of their son to Tereus. Behind
her follows Philomela, her
mouth open as if trying to
speak, wreathed with ivy and
carrying the Maenad's thyrsus.
Tereus has kicked over the table,
and he reaches for his sword with
which to kill Procne. In the background,
a servant watches from a half-
opened door, and a putto
looks on from above. (*Erich
Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

saved by Hermes at Apollo's request and taken by Apollo to Delphi, where he was brought up as a temple servant and became treasurer of the sanctuary. Creusa, meanwhile, was given as wife to Xuthus as a reward for helping Erechtheus defeat the Chalcodontids of Euboea. After years of childlessness, Xuthus and Creusa consulted the Delphic oracle as to how they might have children; Xuthus was told to greet as his son the first person he met on going out of the temple.¹⁰ This person was Ion, but Creusa, who did not know that he was her own son, took him for a bastard son of Xuthus and attempted to kill him. The attempt miscarried, and with the intervention of Athena, mother and son recognized each other. Xuthus, Creusa, and Ion returned together to Athens, where Ion became the ancestor of the four Ionic tribes (which were the main units of the early Athenian political structure). His descendants colonized part of the coast of Asia Minor and the islands, thereafter called Ionia.¹¹

Orithyia and Boreas and Their Children

Another daughter of Erechtheus, Orithyia, was loved by the North Wind, Boreas. He carried her off to Thrace as she was playing by the river Ilissus.¹² In Thrace, she became the mother of the winged heroes **Zetes** and **Calaïs**, and of two daughters, Cleopatra and Chione. Zetes and Calaïs were prominent in the Argonauts' expedition (see p. 612). Phineus was married to Cleopatra, who was said to have caused the blindness of her stepsons (born to Phineus from another woman) by falsely accusing them of attempting to seduce her. Chione became the mother, by Poseidon, of Eumolpus, whose expedition against Athens we discussed earlier.

The Confused Genealogy of the Kings of Athens

According to Apollodorus, Erechtheus was succeeded by his son Cecrops, and Cecrops by his son Pandion; Cecrops and Pandion thus repeat the names of earlier kings. Pandion was driven out of Attica by his uncle Metion and fled to Megara, where he became the father of four sons: Aegeus, Pallas, Nisus, and Lycus. After Pandion's death, the four brothers recovered the throne at Athens and shared the power; Aegeus, however, as the oldest, was in effect the sovereign, while Nisus returned to Megara as its king.

Theseus

Aegeus, like Erechtheus, is another form of the god Poseidon. This is indicated by his connection with the **Aegean Sea** and by the tradition that Poseidon rather than Aegeus was Theseus' father.¹³ As king of Athens, Aegeus was threatened by the opposition of his brother **Pallas**. Being childless, Aegeus was told by the Delphic oracle "not to undo the wineskin's mouth" until he had returned home. Perplexed by this riddle, he asked the advice of **Pittheus**, king of **Troezen**, his host on the journey. Pittheus, who understood the oracle, made Aegeus drunk and gave him his daughter **Aethra** to lie with.¹⁴ When Aegeus left Troezen, he told Aethra that if their child were a boy she must bring him up without saying who his father was. She was to send him to Athens when he was old enough to lift a rock by himself, under which Aegeus would leave a sword and a pair of sandals as tokens by which he could recognize his son. In due time, Aethra bore a son, Theseus, who grew up and set out for Athens after securing the tokens.

Theseus is the great national hero of Attica, and Athens came to be the focal point of his legends. His earlier links with Marathon and Troezen were weakened. He is associated with Heracles in some of his adventures, and his deeds are similar to those of Heracles—for example, his ridding the land of brigands

Mary Renault's Theseus

An entertaining novel retelling the life of Theseus in a very compelling fashion is *The King Must Die* (1958) by Mary Renault, who is exceptional in her ability to make classical mythology and legend come alive. Robert Graves is another so gifted, for example, in his novel *Hercules, My Shipmate* (1945).

Renault has a firm grasp of both the ancient sources and modern archaeology, and by her sensitive art she has re-created the civilization and the characters in a most credible and exciting manner. Dominant among the many political and religious issues in her novel is the overriding motif of Theseus caught in the archetypal battle between matriarchy and patriarchy. This young, inspiring hero could never fall victim to the horrifying, archaic ritual by which the king must die to ensure the dominance and fertility of the earth mother. Renault's sequel, *The Bull from the Sea* (1962), depicts the life of the Amazons, one of whom becomes the mother of Hippolytus.

and monsters and his expedition against the Amazons. Some of the characters in his saga were themselves heroes with cults of their own, for example, Sciron and Hippolytus. The legends of Theseus have become famous largely through the genius of Athenian writers.¹⁵

Theseus' Six Labors on His Journey from Troezen to Athens

The adventures of Theseus fall into fairly well-defined groups,¹⁶ of which the first contains six deeds he performed while traveling to Athens from Troezen. To expose himself to the challenge of more dangerous adventures, Theseus chose the land route.

At Epidaurus he killed the brigand **Periphetes**, a son of Hephaestus, who was armed with a club and generally called **Corynetes (Club Man)**. Theseus took the club for himself, and it plays no further part in his legend (except in artistic representations).

At the Isthmus of Corinth, Theseus killed the robber **Sinis**, called **Pityocampetes (Pine Bender)** from the way in which he killed his victims. He would bend two pine tree saplings to the ground, tie one end of his victim to each of the two trees, and then release the trees. Theseus killed him in this way.

On the border of the Isthmus and the Megarid, Theseus killed a **monstrous sow** near the village of **Crommyon**. Next he found the brigand **Sciron** barring his way at the so-called Cliffs of Sciron. Sciron, originally a local hero of neighboring areas,¹⁷ blocked the path along which travelers through the Megarid must go to pass the cliffs and compelled all comers to stoop and wash his feet. He



The Labors of Theseus. Attic red-figure kylix, ca. 475 B.C.; height of kylix 5 in., diameter 12 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. The cycle of Theseus' labors was often painted on Athenian vases, especially drinking cups (*kylikes*), in the fifth century. This cup is unusual in that the cycle is painted (almost identically, except for the Minotaur) on both the exterior and interior. The interior, with the Minotaur at the center, is shown here. Starting at the top and going in a clockwise direction the labors are: (1) Cercyon; (2) Procrustes; (3) Sciron (note the turtle); (4) the bull of Marathon; (5) Sinis (Pityocampetes); (6) the sow of Crommyon. At the center Theseus drags the dying Minotaur out of the Labyrinth to dispatch him with his sword. Periphetes does not appear, since this labor does not enter the cycle until after 475 B.C. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



Closer Look

would then kick his victims into the sea, where a gigantic turtle ate them up. Theseus killed him by his own methods.

Drawing closer to Athens, Theseus met **Cercyon** at Eleusis. Like Sciron, Cercyon was also originally a local hero. He compelled travelers to wrestle with him to the death. Theseus defeated him in wrestling, held him high in the air, and then dashed him to his death upon the ground.

Finally, between Eleusis and Athens, Theseus met the brigand **Procrustes** (his name means “**the stretcher**”),¹⁸ who possessed a hammer, a saw, and a bed. He compelled travelers to lie on the bed, and those who were too long for it he would cut down to size; those who were too short he would hammer out until they fit it exactly. He, too, perished at Theseus’ hands in the way in which he had killed his victims.

Theseus Is Recognized by Aegeus

Theseus’ arrival at Athens is dramatically described by the lyric poet Bacchylides of Ceos. In reply to the citizens’ questions, Aegeus speaks (Bacchylides, *Dithyramb* 18. 16–60):

“A messenger has come, traversing the long road from the Isthmus; incredible are the deeds of a mighty man that he relates. This man killed violent Sinis, strongest of mortals. He killed the man-slaying sow in the glens of Crommyon and killed the cruel Sciron. The wrestling ring of Cercyon has he suppressed; Procoptes [Slicer, i.e., Procrustes] has dropped the mighty hammer of Polypemon [Troubler, i.e., Procrustes’ father?], for he has met a more valiant man. I fear what this news portends.” “Who is this man?” [ask the citizens, and Aegeus continues]: “Two companions only come with him, says the messenger; upon his shoulders he wears an ivory-hilted sword, and in his hand he carries two polished spears; upon his red-haired head is set a Spartan cap, well-made; around his body he has cast a purple tunic and over it a woolen cloak from Thessaly. From his eyes darts blood-red flame, as from Lemnos’ volcano. Yet he is but a youth in his first prime, whose skill is in the delight of war and the brazen blows of battle. In quest of shining Athens does he come.” 10

Theseus’ arrival was hedged with further danger. Aegeus was married to **Medea**, who expected their son Medus to succeed as king of Athens. Medea, immediately recognizing Theseus as Aegeus’ son and a rival to Medus, attempted to have Theseus poisoned before Aegeus could recognize him. She advised Aegeus that the newcomer would be a threat to his power. He should entertain Theseus at a banquet where he would drink poisoned wine, for which Medea would provide the poison. Theseus at the banquet carved his meat with the sword that he had recovered from under the rock at Troezen; Aegeus recognized the sword, dashed the cup of poison out of Theseus’ hand, and publicly recognized him as his son and successor.

Pallas, brother of Aegeus, and his sons had hoped and plotted to take over Aegeus’ power and resorted to violence upon Theseus’ recognition. Theseus killed all the members of one of the two groups into which they had divided, and Pallas himself and his surviving sons ceased to be a threat.

The Bull of Marathon

Theseus' next labor was to catch the bull of Marathon, which was said to have been the one that Heracles had brought from Crete. He mastered the bull and drove it back to Athens, where he sacrificed it to Apollo Delphinus. On his way to Marathon an old woman, **Hecale**, entertained Theseus. She promised she would sacrifice to Zeus if Theseus returned successful, but on his return he found her already dead and ordered that she share the honors henceforth paid to Zeus Hecalus at a local annual festival.

The Minotaur

Androgeos, son of the Cretan king **Minos**, had been killed in Attica because of the jealousy he aroused by winning all the contests at the Panathenaic games. In revenge, Minos mounted an expedition against Athens and her ally, Megara, where Nisus, brother of Aegeus, was king. Megara was attacked first, and some time after its fall Athens made a treaty with Minos, with the provision that at intervals (of one or nine years) seven Athenian youths and seven girls, children of noble families, should be sent to Crete as tribute, there to be shut up in the Labyrinth and devoured by the Minotaur. The victims were chosen by lot, and Theseus volunteered to go.¹⁹

On the voyage to Crete, Minos attacked one of the maidens, Eriboea, who called on Theseus for help. When Theseus intervened, Minos prayed to Zeus for a sign that he was indeed Minos' father (and therefore that his son need be under no restraint in dealing with other men). Zeus sent lightning, and Minos then challenged Theseus' claim to be the son of Poseidon by throwing a ring



Theseus and Amphitrite. Attic red-figure cup by the painter Onesimos and signed by the potter Euphronios, ca. 500 B.C.; diameter 15 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. The boyish figure of Theseus is held up underwater by a tiny Triton, as dolphins cavort to the left. Amphitrite, seated on a stool, holds the wreath in her left hand, as Athena (with helmet, spear, and aegis) looks toward her. This scene anticipates the narrative of Bacchylides by some twenty-five years. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

overboard, which Theseus was to recover. A beautiful poem by Bacchylides describes the sequel (*Dithyramb* 17. 92–116):

The Athenian youths trembled as the hero leaped into the sea, and tears poured from their lilylike eyes as they awaited the sorrow of what had to be. Yet the dolphins, dwellers in the sea, swiftly brought great Theseus to the palace of his father, the ruler of horses. There with awe he saw the noble daughters of rich Nereus, and in the lovely palace he saw his father's own wife, the beauteous Amphitrite, in all her majesty. Round him she cast a purple robe, and upon his thick hair the unwithered wreath, dark with roses, which subtle Aphrodite had given her at her own marriage.

With these gifts (the poet does not mention the ring), Theseus returned miraculously to the ship and so came to Crete. There the daughter of Minos, **Ariadne**, fell in love with him and gave him a thread with which he could trace his way back out of the **Labyrinth**. With this aid he entered the Labyrinth, killed the **Minotaur**, and emerged unharmed. He then sailed from Crete with his thirteen Athenian companions, taking Ariadne with him.

Ariadne on Naxos

Another tradition, however, makes Ariadne give Theseus a wreath that lights up the darkness of the Labyrinth and so helps him escape. In the poem of Bacchylides, this wreath is made the gift not of Ariadne but of Amphitrite, so that Theseus himself brings it to Crete. Ariadne wore the wreath on her flight with Theseus until he deserted her on Naxos and she was found by **Dionysus**. The god took the wreath and set it in the heavens, where it became the constellation Corona.

Here is Ovid's version of the metamorphosis (*Metamorphoses* 8. 174–181):

Quickly the son of Aegeus sailed to Dia after seizing Minos' daughter and cruelly left his companion deserted on that shore. Alone and bitterly complaining, Ariadne found comfort in the embraces of Bacchus, who took the wreath from her brow and placed it in the heavens so that Ariadne might be made famous by a constellation. The wreath flies through the thin air, and as it flies its jewels are turned into fires and become fixed in their place, still with the appearance of a wreath (*corona*).

Ariadne is originally a divine person, perhaps another form of Aphrodite. Hesiod (*Theogony* 947–949) describes her as the “wife of Dionysus, whom Zeus made immortal.” Later versions of the Theseus legend make her a forlorn heroine, deserted by her lover Theseus upon the island of Dia (the early name for Naxos) during the voyage back to Athens. Here is the narrative of Catullus (64. 52–59):

Ariadne, with uncontrolled passion in her heart, looking out from the shore of Dia with its sounding waves, saw Theseus receding into the distance with his fleet at full speed. Not yet could she believe her eyes, for she had only just been wakened from deceitful sleep and saw that she was alone, unhappy, upon the shore. But the young man, forgetful, parted the waves with his oars in flight, leaving his promises unfulfilled to the gusts of wind.



Ovid, who related this legend three times,²⁰ describes the arrival of Dionysus and his companions (*Ars amatoria* 1. 535–564):

And now Ariadne beat her soft breast again and again: “My faithless lover has gone,” cried she. “What will become of me?” “What will become of me?” she cried; the shore reechoed to the sound of cymbals and the frenzied beating of drums. She swooned in fear, and her words trailed away; no blood remained in her fainting body. Look! here are the maenads, their hair streaming down their backs. Look! here come the dancing satyrs, forerunners of the god. Look! here is old Silenus, hardly able to keep his seat upon the swaybacked donkey. . . . And now came the god in his chariot decked to the top with vines, driving yoked tigers with golden reins. Ariadne lost her color, her voice, her thoughts of Theseus; thrice she tried to run away, and thrice fear held her rooted. . . . Then said the god: “Behold I am here, a more faithful object of your love. Away with fear! You shall be the Cretan wife of Bacchus. Take the heavens as my gift; you shall be observed in the heavens as a constellation. Often as the Cretan Crown (Corona) will you guide lost sailors.” So he spoke and jumped down from the chariot, lest she be alarmed by the tigers, and took her up in his arms, for she could not resist; all things are easy for a god. Some of his followers chant the marriage cry, “O Hymen,” and others cry, “*Evoe, evoe*,” so the god and his bride lay together in the sacred bed.

Death of a Monster, by Pablo Picasso (1881–1973); pencil on paper, 1937, 15 × 22¼ in. The contorted and dying Minotaur sees himself in a mirror held up by a sea-goddess, perhaps Amphitrite herself. Picasso used the violence and horror of the Minotaur to express his anger at the atrocities of the Spanish Civil War; this drawing is dated December 6, 1937, eight months after the bombing of Guernica. (© 2014 estate of Pablo Picasso/Artist's Rights Society (ARS)/Scottish National Gallery of Modern Art; Purchased with the support of the Heritage Lottery Fund and the Art Fund 1995)

Homer says that Ariadne was killed by Artemis upon Naxos as a punishment for eloping with Theseus when she was already betrothed to Dionysus. Yet another story has her die in Cyprus in giving birth to Theseus' child. When Theseus returned, he instituted a ritual in her honor. In historical times, she was honored under the title of Ariadne Aphrodite, part of the ritual being for a young man to lie down and imitate a woman in childbirth. In all these conflicting stories, it is clear that Ariadne is no ordinary mortal and that her partner was not a man, Theseus, but a god.

Theseus Becomes King of Athens

After leaving Dia (Naxos), Theseus went to Delos, where he sacrificed to Apollo and danced the **Crane dance** with his companions. The dance became traditional at Delos, and its intricate movements were said to imitate the windings of the Labyrinth.²¹ From Delos Theseus sailed home to Athens. Now he had arranged with Aegeus that he should change the black sail of his ship for white if he had been successful. This he forgot to do, and as Aegeus saw the black-sailed ship approaching, he threw himself from a cliff into the sea, which thereafter was called the **Aegean Sea**.

So Theseus became king of Athens. He was credited with a number of historical reforms and institutions, including the **synoecism** of Attica (i.e., the union of the different villages into one political unit with Athens as its center) and the refounding of the **Isthmian Games**.²²

The Amazons

Theseus joined with Heracles in his expedition against the Amazons, and as his share of the spoil received the Amazon, **Antiope**, by whom he became the father of **Hippolytus**. The Amazons in revenge invaded Attica and were defeated by Theseus. During the Amazon attack, Antiope died. The battle between Theseus and the Amazons became a favorite theme in Athenian art after the Persian Wars, when the Amazons were seen as symbols of the barbarians, who, like the Persians, had been defeated by the Greeks.²³

Theseus and Pirithoüs

Pirithoüs, king of the Thessalian tribe of the **Lapiths** and son of Ixion, was Theseus' friend. Theseus was among the guests at the marriage of Pirithoüs and took part in the fight against the **centaurs**, which became an important theme in Greek art.

Theseus and Pirithoüs vowed to help each other in securing a wife. Theseus attempted to take **Helen**, and Pirithoüs, **Persephone**. Helen, who at the time was only a child, was kidnapped from Sparta and brought back to Attica, where she was put in the care of Theseus' mother, Aethra, in the Attic village of Aphidnae. While Theseus and Pirithoüs were away on their attempt against Persephone, the **Dioscuri** invaded Attica and recovered their sister. The Dioscuri were favorably received in Athens itself, where the regent Menestheus instituted a cult in their honor.²⁴ Aethra was taken back to Sparta as Helen's servant and went with her to Troy.



Dionysus and Ariadne. Marble sarcophagus, ca. A.D. 180; width 77 in., height (without lid) 20 ½ in., height of lid 11 in. Dionysus approaches from the left riding on a chariot drawn by a lyre-playing centaur, in front of and to the right of whom a centauress blows on a kind of trumpet. Before him go Pan and a silenus, and a silenus mask lies on the ground in the left center. A cupid hovers near the god. In the center the god stands, now clothed in a long robe, holding a reversed thyrsus in his left hand, his right hand resting on the leading silenus. He looks toward the sleeping Ariadne, whose robe is being drawn aside by a cupid, while two maenads look back at the god. To the right two maenads are about to attack Pentheus. On the lid are reliefs of the god's thiasos, and a deer (far right) is being sacrificed. The waking of Ariadne to the coming of the god of new life was popular in the funerary art of late antiquity as a parable of the waking of the soul to eternal life after death. This sarcophagus is in a tomb in the cemetery under St. Peter's Basilica in the Vatican. It is not known whether its occupant was pagan or Christian. (Photo courtesy of the Foto Fabbrica di San Pietro, Vatican)

Pirithoüs met his end in attempting to abduct Persephone. He and Theseus descended to the Underworld where they were held fast in magic chairs. In the Athenian tradition, **Heracles** interceded for Theseus' release, while Pirithoüs stayed in Hades forever. Thus the Athenian hero was again associated with Heracles, in this case in his last and greatest labor, the conquest of death.

Theseus, Phaedra, and Hippolytus

Theseus was also married to Phaedra, another daughter of Minos, and she bore him two sons, Demophon and Acamas. Phaedra (whose name means "bright") may originally have been a Cretan goddess like Ariadne. As we learned in Chapter 10, she fell passionately in love with Hippolytus, Theseus' son by Antiope, but did not tell him of her desire. During an absence of Theseus, her old nurse found out the secret and told Hippolytus. In shame at the discovery of her secret, Phaedra hanged herself and left behind a letter falsely accusing Hippolytus of attempting to seduce her. When Theseus returned, saw Phaedra's corpse, and read the letter, he banished Hippolytus and called on Poseidon to destroy him.²⁵ As Hippolytus was driving his chariot along



Closer Look



the seashore on his way into exile, Poseidon sent a bull from the sea, which so frightened the horses that they bolted, threw Hippolytus from the chariot, and dragged him almost to his death. He was carried back to Theseus and died after a reconciliation with his father, assured by Artemis of his future honor as a hero with a cult.

The legend of Hippolytus owes its fame largely to Euripides, who wrote two tragedies on the subject (one of which is extant), and to Seneca, whose *Phaedra* was the model for Racine's *Phèdre*.²⁶ In Euripides' *Hippolytus*, the drama is set at Troezen; but most other authors make Athens the scene. Hippolytus himself was honored with a cult at Troezen and was closely connected with Artemis, in whose honor he avoided all women. At Athens he was connected with Aphrodite, whose temple on the south side of the Acropolis was called "Aphrodite by Hippolytus." Hippolytus himself was said to have been brought to life by Asclepius, and in his resurrected form he was absorbed by the Italians with the name of Virbius. His legend is of the greatest literary importance: it connects Attica and Troezen and links Theseus to the great goddesses worshiped in Crete, Troezen, and Athens.

Theseus as Champion of the Oppressed

In the fifth century, a number of legends were developed in which kings of Athens were portrayed as protectors of victims of tyranny who had been driven from their homes. In Euripides' *Medea*, Aegeus, father of Theseus, promises to protect Medea, who has been exiled from Corinth. Theseus was especially popular in these legends. He generously gave refuge to the exiled Oedipus (see pp. 419–423),



Dionysus and Ariadne. Bronze krater (the Derveni Krater), second half of the fourth century B.C.; height 35½ in. The krater, which held the ashes of a Thessalian nobleman, was discovered at Derveni, not far from Thessalonike, in 1962. The reliefs on the central panel show Dionysus, naked, seated on a rock with his leg over Ariadne's thigh. She draws her veil aside, the gesture of a bride accepting her husband. Behind Dionysus is a panther, and birds, animals, vines, and ivy ornament the neck and body of the krater. Figures of maenads flank the divine pair, and in the upper register the seated Dionysus gestures toward a sleeping maenad. The handles, in the form of serpents, frame the head of a horned god to the left and of Heracles (with lionskin over his head) to the right. (Top: Archaeological Museum, Thessaloniki, Greece, © Vanni/Art Resource, NY; Bottom: The Art Archive/Archaeological Museum Salonica/Gianni Dagli Orti)



Closer Look

and in the *Suppliant Women* of Euripides he champions the mothers of the dead heroes of the Seven against Thebes. Led by Adrastus, the sole survivor of the expedition, they come to Eleusis, where Aethra has come to sacrifice to Demeter. She takes pity on the women and appeals to Theseus to protect them and help them persuade the Theban king Creon to allow them to bury the dead Argive princes. Theseus is at first unpersuaded by her pleas and those of Adrastus, but eventually he relents and attacks Thebes with an Athenian army. He returns victorious, bringing the bodies of the dead Argive leaders, over whom Adrastus makes a funeral oration. The bodies are then cremated, although the pyre of Capaneus is separate from the others because he was killed by the thunderbolt of Zeus and therefore is sacred to the god. In the climactic scene of the tragedy, Evadne, the widow of Capaneus, hurls herself into the flames of his pyre (see p. 428).

The figure of Theseus as the noble king has frequently been portrayed in later literature. He is the compassionate champion of the Argive women in the twelfth book of Statius' *Thebaid*, in which he actually kills Creon. In Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* he is, in "The Knight's Tale," the protector of the Argive women and the wise king. He is rather less loftily called "Duke Theseus" in Shakespeare's *Midsummer Night's Dream*.

Other Adventures of Theseus

Theseus was not originally a member of the great expeditions of saga, but this important national hero naturally came to be included in the roster of heroic adventurers, so that he was said to have been an Argonaut and one of those present on the Calydonian boar hunt. Indeed, "not without Theseus" became an Athenian proverb, and he was called "a second Heracles." His life was said

Theseus in Greek Tragedy

In a meticulous and lucid study, Sophie Mills distinguishes Theseus in the *Hippolytus* of Euripides as individual and quite different from his depiction in other plays and explains why this is the case.²⁷ Basic elements in the legend of Theseus—for example, his abduction of Helen, his ill-fated journey to the Underworld, his Cretan adventure, and the Centauromachy—were developed in Greece long before the fifth century. In Attica, however, with the emergence of democracy and the establishment of the Athenian Empire, an idealized portrait of Theseus was deliberately created to exemplify and glorify the character of the individual, the state, and the empire. The legend of Theseus was cleansed of any dubious traits, and Theseus himself, thus purified, was artfully transformed into an ideological paradigm, an honorable hero, brave and just, representing Athenian intelligence and virtue. This is the Theseus in Euripides' *Suppliants* and *Heracles* and Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus*. The depiction of Theseus in Euripides' *Hippolytus* offers a striking contrast. He is not represented in this play as the heroic king of Athens, noble model for his city and its citizens; instead he is most realistically portrayed as a vulnerable human being, a tragically flawed individual, whose character and actions are integral to the drama.²⁸

to have ended in failure. He was driven out of Athens, his power usurped by Menestheus, who is mentioned in the *Iliad*'s catalogue of ships as the Athenian leader at Troy. Theseus went to the island of Scyros and was there killed by Lycomedes, the local king. Menestheus continued to reign at Athens but died at Troy. The sons of Theseus then recovered their father's throne. After the Persian Wars, the Greek allies, led by the Athenian Cimon, captured Scyros in the years 476–475 B.C. There Cimon, obedient to a command of the Delphic oracle, searched for the bones of Theseus. He found the bones of a very large man with a bronze spearhead and sword and brought them back to Athens. So Theseus returned, a symbol of Athens' connection with the heroic age and of her claim to lead the Ionian Greeks.

Demophon

Theseus' son Demophon helped the children of Heracles (see p. 576), and he has a number of other legends.²⁹ He loved the Thracian princess Phyllis, and on leaving her in Thrace, he swore to return soon. When he never came back, she hanged herself and became an almond tree. Too late he returned and embraced the tree, which then burst into leaf.

Codrus

The last king of Athens was Codrus, who sacrificed himself for his city. The Peloponnesians invaded Attica, assured by the Delphic oracle that the side would win whose king was killed. When Codrus learned of the oracle, he disguised himself as a peasant and provoked a quarrel with some enemy soldiers, who killed him; the Peloponnesians were defeated.

Minos

Daedalus and Minos

Daedalus was the son or grandson of Metion, the younger brother of Cecrops, and therefore a member of the Athenian royal house. He was a skilled craftsman and inventor; his assistant was his nephew **Perdix**.³⁰ One day Perdix invented the saw, getting the idea from a fish's backbone. In a fit of jealousy, Daedalus hurled him from a rock. As he fell, he was turned into a partridge, which still bears the name *perdix*. Being now guilty of homicide, Daedalus had to leave Athens. He went to Crete, where Minos and Pasiphaë employed his skills.

Now Minos had prayed to Poseidon to send him a bull from the sea for sacrifice; when Poseidon answered his prayer, Minos was so covetous that he sacrificed another, less beautiful bull, keeping Poseidon's animal for himself. As a punishment, Poseidon caused his wife, **Pasiphaë**, to fall in love with the bull. To satisfy her passion, Daedalus constructed a lifelike hollow cow in which Pasiphaë was shut up to mate with the bull. Her offspring was the Minotaur. It had a man's body and the head of a bull, and was held captive in the Labyrinth, a mazelike prison of Daedalus' devising. We have already seen how Theseus destroyed it. The famous discoveries at Cnossus in Crete (pp. 40–41) have shown that the bull played a significant part in Cretan ritual and that a common sacred



object was the *labrys*, or double-headed ax, which is certainly connected with the word *labyrinth*. The idea of the maze has plausibly been thought to have its origin in the huge and complex palace of Cnossus, with its many passageways and endless series of rooms. Minos and Pasiphaë, like their daughters Ariadne and Phaedra, are probably divine figures; Minos was son and friend of Zeus,³¹ while Pasiphaë was the daughter of Helius.

The Flight of Icarus

Daedalus eventually tired of his life in Crete, but Minos would not let him go. Daedalus therefore contrived feathered wings, held together by wax, by means of which he and his son Icarus could escape. As they flew high above the sea, Icarus ignored his father's warning not to fly too close to the sun . . . and as the wax on his wings melted he fell into the sea, which thereafter was called *Mare Icarium*. The story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 8. 200–230):

When Daedalus the craftsman had finished [making the wings], he balanced his body between the twin wings and by moving them hung suspended in air. He also gave instructions to his son, saying: "Icarus, I advise you to take a middle course. If you fly too low, the sea will soak the wings; if you fly too high, the sun's

The Fall of Icarus, by Pieter Bruegel the Elder (1525–1569); oil on canvas, 30 × 44 in. Only the legs of Icarus are visible in the sea near the galleon. The ploughman, the fisherman, and the shepherd, observers in Ovid's narrative, here mind their own business. The partridge (Latin name, *perdix*), too, is Ovidian, a reference to Daedalus' rival and victim Perdix: in Ovid it gloats over the burial of Icarus. (*Scala/Art Resource*, NY)



Closer Look



Audio



Icarus, by Henri Matisse (1869–1954); stencil print of a paper cutout, 1947, 16 ½ × 25 ½ in. This is Plate 8 (p. 54) in Matisse's *Jazz* (Paris: Tériade, 1947). The plates were printed from paper cutouts pasted on and painted through stencils. The artist wrote the text in his own firm handwriting, and opposite *Icarus* is the last of seven pages titled *L'Avion* (*The Airplane*). Matisse reflects on the freedom in space experienced by air travelers; then he concludes: "Ought one not to make young people who have finished their studies take a long journey in an airplane." The red heart of Icarus—symbol of his courage and creativity—stands out in the black silhouette against the sky and stars that he tried, and failed, to reach. (Digital Image © The Museum of Modern Art/Licensed by SCALA/Art Resource, NY)

heat will burn them. Fly between sea and sun! Take the course along which I shall lead you." (200–208)

As he gave the instructions for flying, he fitted the novel wings to Icarus' shoulders. While he worked and gave his advice, the old man's face was wet with tears, and his hands trembled with a father's anxiety. For the last time, he kissed his son and rose into the air upon his wings. He led the way in flight and was anxious for his companion, like a bird that leads its young from the nest into the air. He encouraged Icarus to follow and showed him the skills that were to destroy him; he moved his wings and looked back at those of his son. Some fisherman with trembling rod, or shepherd leaning on his crook, or farmer resting on his plow saw them and was amazed, and believed that those who could travel through the air were gods. (208–220)

Now Juno's Samos was on the left (they had already passed Delos and Paros), and Lebinthos and Calymne, rich in honey, were on the right, when the boy began to exult in his bold flight. He left his guide and, drawn by a desire to reach the heavens, took his course too high. The burning heat of the nearby sun softened the scented wax that fastened the wings. The wax melted; Icarus moved his arms, now uncovered, and without the wings to drive him on, vainly beat the air. Even as he called upon his father's name the sea received him and from him took its name. (220–230)

Daedalus himself reached Sicily, where **Cocalus**, king of the city of Camicus, received him.³² Here he was pursued by Minos, who discovered him by the ruse of carrying round a spiral shell, which he asked Cocalus to have threaded. Cocalus gave the shell to Daedalus, who alone of men was ingenious enough to succeed. Minos knew that Daedalus was there when Cocalus gave him back the threaded shell. However, Daedalus still stayed out of Minos' reach, for the daughters of Cocalus drowned Minos in boiling water. There is no reliable legend about the further history or death of Daedalus.

The Family of Minos

Several of the children of Minos and Pasiphaë have their own legends; there were four sons—Catreus, Deucalion, Glaucus, and Androgeos—and four daughters, of whom only Ariadne and Phaedra have important legends.

Catreus, who became the Cretan king, had a son Althaemenes, of whom an oracle foretold that he would kill his father. Althaemenes tried to avoid his fate by leaving Crete and going to Rhodes with his sister Apemosyne.³³ She was seduced by Hermes and killed by Althaemenes as a punishment for her apparent unchastity. Catreus later came to Rhodes in search of his son; he and his party were taken for pirates, and in the ensuing skirmish Catreus was killed by his son. When Althaemenes learned how the oracle had been fulfilled, he avoided the company of other men and was eventually swallowed up by the earth. The Rhodians honored him as a hero.

Of the other sons of Minos, Deucalion (not to be confused with Deucalion of the flood legend) became the father of Idomeneus, the Cretan leader at Troy. As a boy, **Glaucus** fell into a vat of honey and drowned. Minos could not find him and was told by the oracle that the person who could find an exact simile for a magic calf in the herds of Minos would be able both to find Glaucus and to restore him to life. This calf changed color every four hours, from white to red to black; but the seer **Polyidus** most fittingly likened it to a mulberry, which changes from white to red to black as it ripens. With the help of various birds, Polyidus found Glaucus' corpse in the vat. It was placed in a tomb, and Polyidus was then shut up in the tomb and ordered to bring Glaucus back to life. While he was wondering what to do, a snake came. Polyidus killed it with his sword, whereupon another snake came, looked at the dead snake, and went away, returning with an herb, which it put on the dead snake's body. The dead snake then came to life again, and Polyidus took the herb and used it on Glaucus, who likewise came to life. Even now, Minos was not satisfied; he compelled Polyidus to teach Glaucus the seer's art before he would let him return home to Argos. Polyidus obeyed, but as he left, he told Glaucus to spit into his mouth, whereupon Glaucus forgot all that he had learned.³⁴

Androgeos was killed in Attica, and his death led to Minos' expedition and the attack on **Megara**. The king of Megara, **Nisus**, had a purple lock of hair, which was the city's talisman, for the city would fall if the lock were cut off. Now **Scylla**, daughter of Nisus, fell in love with Minos (whom she could see from the city walls). To please him she cut off her father's purple lock and brought it to Minos. When the city fell, Minos rejected Scylla and sailed away; she clung to the stern of his ship and was turned into a sea bird called *ciris*,³⁵ while Nisus turned into a sea eagle, forever pursuing her.

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Catullus	Poem 64.52–59
Euripides	<i>Ion</i> 277–282 <i>Medea</i> 824–830
Ovid	<i>Ars amatoria</i> 1.535–564 <i>Metamorphoses</i> 6.572–674; 7.804–859; 8.174–181, 200–230

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 3.14.5–3.16.2
Isocrates	<i>Speech</i> 10.14–10.69 (encomium of Helen with a lengthy digression on Theseus [10.22–10.37]) <i>Speech</i> 12.119–12.131 (encomium of early Athens and Theseus)
Plutarch	<i>Theseus</i>

Notes

1. According to Ovid, only Aglauros disobeyed Athena.
2. Euripides, *Erechtheus*, frag. 18, 94–98.
3. For the Erechtheum, one might begin by consulting John Travlos, *Pictorial Dictionary of Ancient Athens* (New York: Praeger, 1971): entry for “Erechtheum.” See also G. P. Stevens and J. M. Paton, *The Erechtheum* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1927).
4. The sacrifice of a virgin was the original form of the legend. Later versions give her the name of Chthonia (which means “earth woman”) and have her sisters take an oath to kill themselves so as to die with her. According to others, the names of the daughters of Erechtheus were Pandora, Protogeneia, and Orithyia.
5. Euripides’ *Erechtheus* survives only in fragments; its ending (including a long speech from Athena), first published in 1967, has helped fill out many of the missing details of the relationship between the myth of Erechtheus and his cult. Erechtheus took the title of the god who caused his death (i.e., he became Poseidon-Erechtheus). His

original status as a hero, with a cult located at the place of his burial, was later confused with that of the god. His daughters had become goddesses with the title Hyacinthides, to be worshiped with annual sacrifices and dances.

6. The lines are sung just after Medea has secured the promise of protection from Aegeus.
7. Pandrosos had her own shrine and cult on the Acropolis, close to the Erechtheum. She was the one of the three daughters of Cecrops, to whom, in some versions, Athena had entrusted Erichthonius. Aglauros was worshiped in a cave on the north side of the Acropolis, while the name *Herse* had been connected etymologically with the festival of the *Arrephoria*, in which two specially chosen young girls carried mysterious objects from the Acropolis by night down to the sanctuary of Aphrodite and Eros, which was also on the north side of the Acropolis.
8. Ovid plays on words with a double meaning, literal and erotic, for which English has no adequate equivalent.
9. In another version, Procris was discovered by Cephalus with a lover. She fled to Minos, king of Crete, who himself fell in love with her. He had been bewitched by his wife, Pasiphaë, so that whenever he lay with a woman he discharged snakes and other creatures. Procris cured him and then lay with him, being rewarded with the gift of the hound and the javelin. Later, she returned to Athens and was reconciled with Cephalus.
10. There is a pun here on Ion's name, which is also the Greek word meaning "going."
11. The legend of Ion stems almost entirely from Euripides' play. It explains the historical fact of the colonization of Ionia by mainland Greeks (principally from Athens) during the unsettled period after the collapse of the Mycenaean civilization.
12. The chief source is Plato's *Phaedrus* 229, where Socrates rationalizes the legend: "I would say that the North Wind pushed her, as she was playing, down from the nearby rocks. She died in this way; but her death was described as her being ravished by Boreas."
13. And by his link with the cult of Apollo Delphinus, that is, Apollo as a god of spring, when the sea becomes navigable and the dolphins appear as portents of good sailing weather. See pp. 251 and 273.
14. The oracle is difficult to reconcile with this story if the "home" referred to should be Athens. Euripides has Medea cure Aegeus of his sterility after she has joined him in Athens.
15. Theseus was idealized in the latter part of the sixth century B.C. when Pisistratus was tyrant of Athens, and again immediately after the Persian Wars (ca. 475).
16. The most complete source for the legend of Theseus is Plutarch's *Life of Theseus* (early second century A.D.). This biography blurs the lines between mythology, history, and philosophy.
17. Sciron originally had his own legend and cult at Megara, on the island of Salamis, and in Attica where there were limestone outcrops (his name means "limestone").
18. Procrustes is also called Damastes (Subduer), Procoptes (Slicer), and Polypemon (Troubler). Polypemon may also be the name of his father.
19. According to the fifth-century historian Hellanicus, Minos himself chose the victims and took them on his ship back to Crete.
20. Respectively, in the tenth letter of the *Heroides*; in *Ars amatoria* 1. 527–564; and in *Metamorphoses* 8. 174–192.
21. This dance was represented on the François Vase (ca. 575 B.C.). At Athens, Theseus instituted the *Oschophoria* in which two boys disguised as girls carried vine branches in a procession to honor Bacchus and Ariadne.
22. Sisyphus, a son of Aeolus and brother of Salmoneus, Cretheus, and Athamas, came from Thessaly to Ephyra. Ino, the wife of his brother Athamas, leaped into the sea with her child Melicertes and became the sea-goddess Leucothea, while her child became the god Palaemon. Melicertes' body was brought ashore on the Isthmus of

Corinth by a dolphin. Sisyphus found and buried it, instituting the Isthmian Games in the child's honor. At first, the games were mainly religious and ritualistic; Theseus is said to have founded them a second time and thus gave them the athletic character that they acquired in historical times.

23. In Athens, the battle with the Amazons was depicted in the Hephaestum and in the Stoa Poecile (Painted Colonnade); it was one of the subjects of the metopes of the Parthenon and was depicted on the shield of Pheidias' statue of Athena Parthenos. It also appeared on the pedestal of the statue of Zeus at Olympia.
24. They were referred to by the title of *Anakes* or *Anaktes* (Kings), and their temple was called the *Anakeion*.
25. Poseidon was said to have granted Theseus three wishes, of which this was the third. The others were to escape from the Labyrinth and to return from Hades.
26. Twentieth-century dramatic adaptations of the myth include *The Cretan Woman* by Robinson Jeffers and *Desire under the Elms* by Eugene O'Neill.
27. Sophie Mills, *Theseus, Tragedy and the Athenian Empire* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1997).
28. The surviving tragedy of *Hippolytus* was Euripides' second to present this myth: the first, *Hippolytus Veiled* (now mostly lost), did not, apparently, present Theseus more favorably. Euripides presented five other tragedies (now mostly lost) on Athenian mythical subjects: *Aegeus*, *Antiope*, *Erechtheus*, *Theseus* (focusing on Theseus' killing of the Minotaur and his abandonment of Ariadne), and *Cretans* (focusing on Minos and Pasiphae). He also presented a satyr-play, *Sciron*, in which a band of satyrs was released from servitude to Sciron after Theseus had killed him.
29. He was said to have succeeded Menestheus as Athenian leader at Troy and to have brought his grandmother Aethra back to Athens.
30. The boy is also called Talus, and his mother, Daedalus' sister, Perdix.
31. Homer (*Odyssey* 19. 178–179) describes him as the intimate friend of Zeus; and Hesiod (frag. 103) calls him “the most kingly of mortal kings, who ruled over most subjects and held his scepter from Zeus.”
32. In the opening lines of the sixth book of Vergil's *Aeneid*, Daedalus comes to Cumae in Italy.
33. Two other sisters are mentioned: Aërope, who became the wife of a Mycenaean prince (either Pleisthenes or Atreus); and Clymene, who became the wife of Nauplius and the mother of Palamedes.
34. Forgetfulness induced by spitting is a folktale motif, as is also the seer who can understand the ways of birds and snakes.
35. Its identification is unknown. According to Aeschylus, Scylla was bribed by Minos with a golden necklace to betray Nisus.

Jason, Medea, and the Argonauts

And now is all that ancient story told
Of him who won the guarded fleece of gold.

—WILLIAM MORRIS, *The Life and Death of Jason*



The Minyae

The saga of the Argonauts covers much of the Greek world in its geographical scope and includes many of the leading Greek heroes of the age before the Trojan War. The crew of the **Argo** included the flower of Greece, descendants of gods and ancestors of Greek nobles. They are often referred to as **Minyae**, and among cities that claimed Minyan descent were **Iolcus** in Thessaly and Miletus in Ionia. Jason belonged to the ruling family of Iolcus, and the Euxine Sea (i.e., the Black Sea), where the main part of the saga takes place, was an area particularly colonized by the Milesians.

The name *Minyae* therefore tells us something about the origin of the saga. Homer calls the *Argo* “all men’s concern,” reflecting the adventures of the seamen of Mycenaean Greece. Later additions reflect the expansion of the Greeks into the Black Sea area from the eighth century onward. Folktale elements can be seen in the name **Aea** (which means no more than “land”) that Homer uses for the country to which the *Argo* sailed, and its king, **Aeëtes** (Man of the Land). It is a mysterious land on the edge of the world, a suitable setting for a story in which magic and miracle play a big part. The folktale element can further be